

## BODY/GENERAL PAIN

- A patient has body/general pain if his/her body aches all over or most of body is painful.
- If pain localised to one area: if in back →63, arm/hand →64, leg →65, foot →66, neck →64.

### Approach to the patient with body/general pain

- If on abacavir or zidovudine, check for urgent side effects ↗ 116.
- If unintentional weight loss of ≥ 5% of body weight in past 4 weeks ↗ 23.
- Are there any of: temperature ≥ 38°C, cough, blocked/runny nose, sore throat?

No

#### Screen for joint problem:

- Ask patient to place hands behind head, then behind back. Bury nails in palm and open hand. Press palms together with elbows lifted. Walk. Sit and stand up with arms folded.
- Is patient able to do all actions comfortably?

No

Check joints: are joint/s warm, tender, swollen or have limited movement?

Yes

→62

No

- Test for HIV ↗ 110.
- If low mood, stress or anxiety ↗ 86.
- Review patient's medication. If on simvastatin and muscle pain/cramps and weakness, reduce **simvastatin** dose to 20mg at night. If no better, reduce dose further to 10mg or discuss with doctor/specialist.
- If patient has a life-limiting illness, also consider giving palliative care ↗ 170.
- Ask about duration of pain:

< 4 weeks

- Give **paracetamol** 1g 4-6 hourly (up to 4g in 24 hours) as needed for up to 5 days.
- Advise to return if no better after 2 weeks.

≥ 4 weeks

- Give **paracetamol** 1g 4-6 hourly (up to 4g in 24 hours) as needed for up to 5 days. Advise to only use analgesia when necessary and avoid long term regular use.
- Assess and advise on chronic pain ↗ 61.
- Check glucose ↗ 17.
- Check Hb: if < 12 (woman) or < 13 (man) ↗ 27.
- Check CRP, creatinine (eGFR). If weakness/tiredness, weight gain, low mood, dry skin, constipation or cold intolerance, also check TSH. Review in 2 weeks:
  - If blood results normal, consider **fibromyalgia** →153.
  - If blood results abnormal, refer to doctor.

Yes

Yes

- If temperature ≥ 38°C →24.
- If cough →38.
- If blocked/runny nose →34.
- If sore throat →35.
- If abdominal pain ↗ 44.
- If nausea or vomiting ↗ 45.
- If diarrhoea ↗ 46.
- If burning urine ↗ 59.
- If none of these:

Is there *recent* onset body pain, headache, fever, or nausea/vomiting?

Yes

If neck stiffness, drowsy/confused or purple/red rash, **meningitis** likely →30.

No

Discuss with doctor.

#### Acute viral infection likely

- If fever, chills or body pain, **influenza** or **COVID-19** more likely. Consider COVID-19 ↗ 40.
- Advise on cough/sneeze hygiene and to wash hands regularly.
- For pain or fever, give **paracetamol** 1g 4-6 hourly (up to 4g in 24 hours) as needed for up to 5 days.
- Advise antibiotics are not needed.
- Advise to return if symptoms persist > 7 days, or if fever returns and any of:
  - Cough ↗ 38.
  - Ear pain ↗ 33.
  - Pain over cheeks, **sinusitis** likely ↗ 30.
  - Advise yearly influenza vaccine if HIV, heart or lung disease.

<sup>†</sup>Test for malaria with rapid diagnostic test if available, and parasite slide microscopy.